

# Security & Environment Configuration

## Apology and Explanation

We sincerely apologize for any inconvenience caused by the absence of the `.env.local` file from the submitted GitHub repository. This was an intentional security measure taken to protect private credentials and environment-specific configuration values used by services such as Firebase. The `.env.local` file has therefore been excluded from the repository using `.gitignore` rather than exposing private keys in the source code.

To make the configuration structure clear, we have included an `.env.example` file containing the required environment-variable names and format, without any actual credentials. To run the Firebase-connected application locally, the evaluator can create a `.env.local` file based on `.env.example` and provide the appropriate Firebase configuration values. This is an intentional security practice and does not indicate a missing or incomplete implementation.

**For a quick demonstration:** If you are accessing the deployed/demo version of the website, you can simply press **Register** and continue into the application to explore and evaluate the working features and overall demo. No existing account is required for the demo experience.

We followed this approach so that the complete source code and project structure can be safely shared while keeping private credentials protected. Thank you for your understanding and consideration.